The North-South DIVIDE

THE SOUTH'S RESISTANCE TO THE DELIMITATION EXERCISE–TO PRESERVE ITS POLITICAL VOICE, FEDERAL AUTONOMY, AND ECONOMIC CONTRIBUTIONS–IS AT ODDS WITH THE NORTH'S CRIES OF UNDER-REPRESENTATION

By **AMARNATH K. MENON and KAUSHIK DEKA**

The south of India is drawing a thick red line. At an all-party meeting convened by Tamil Nadu chief minister M.K. Stalin on March 5, leaders from across the state declared war against the upcoming delimitation exercise, calling it a calculated assault on their "political relevance". Stalin warned that the plan, if executed on raw population figures, would punish the southern states for successfully controlling their birth rates, while rewarding the North that had not. Karnataka CM Siddaramaiah, Telangana's A. Revanth Reddy, and Kerala's Pinarayi Vijayan have voiced similar apprehensions, warning that a weaker parliamentary presence for the South would translate into diminished central allocations, further deepening the divisions between the two regions.

A realignment based solely on population would mean that the northern states, with their sheer numbers, would further consolidate their influence over national politics. This, the southern states believe, could alter the country's federal balance, making it harder for them to safeguard their interests in critical policy matters. Even Andhra Pradesh CM N. Chandrababu Naidu, a BJP ally, has expressed unease, hinting that states might be forced to rethink population policies just to retain influence.

In Tamil Nadu, opposition to delimitation cuts across party lines. Almost all political parties, except for the BJP, view it as a discriminatory move that undermines the federal spirit of the Constitution. CM Stalin also sees delimitation as part of a larger pattern of the Centre trying to encroach on Tamil Nadu's autonomy. He has repeatedly accused the Union government of undermining the state's financial and educational



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